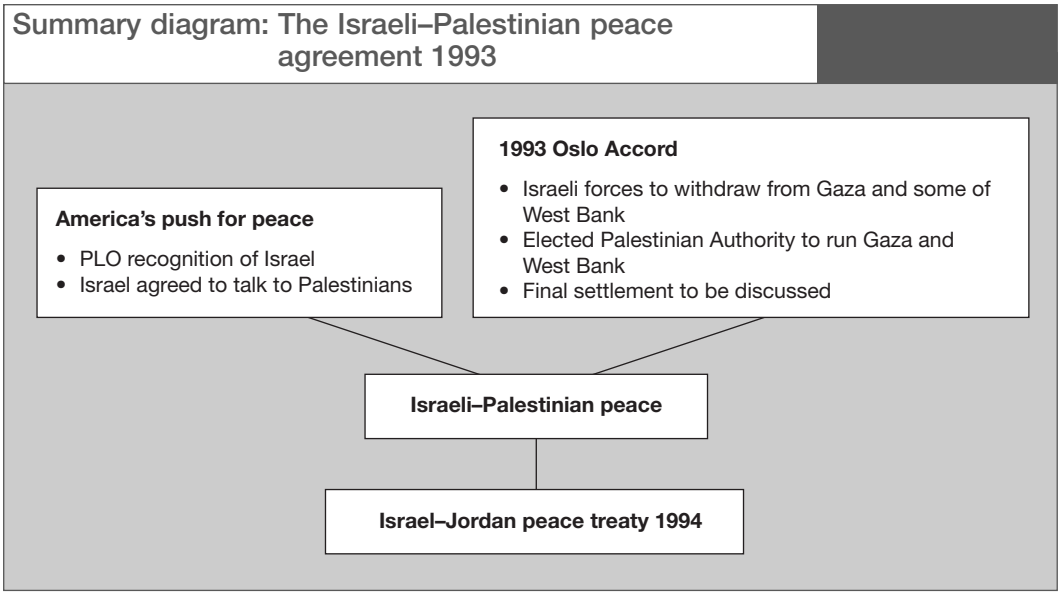


2 | The Problems of Peace-making 1993–9

Key question
What were the issues to be resolved before a final settlement could be agreed?

The Oslo peace agreements were intended to build confidence and trust between the Israelis and the Palestinians. This they did. The most difficult questions were to be discussed, over the five years from 1993 to 1998, before a final settlement was reached. The main issues were:

- *The future of Jerusalem*. Both Israelis and Palestinians wanted it as their capital. The Israelis were determined to ensure that they continued to control all of the city and that it remained *their* capital. By the late 1990s, east Jerusalem, which was mostly Arab, was encircled by Israeli settlements containing 150,000 Israelis.
- *Jewish settlements in the occupied territories*. What would happen to the numerous Jewish settlements on the West Bank? Should they be given up? If not, should Israeli troops continue to guard those settlements and protect the Jewish inhabitants?
- *An independent Palestinian state*. Would most Palestinians agree to a state which was limited to the West Bank and Gaza or would many demand all of Palestine (meaning the end of Israel)? Even if a Palestinian state was limited to the West Bank and Gaza, Palestinians would surely want a completely independent state. Yet if Israeli troops stayed on the West Bank, then it would not be part of a completely independent Palestine, simply because Israeli (i.e. foreign) troops were stationed there. The Israelis, for their part, were worried about their security. They suspected that many Palestinians would not be satisfied with a mini-state and that Israel would constantly face the threat of destruction.
- *The Palestinian refugees' right to return*. Would the refugees in Lebanon, Syria, Jordan and other Arab countries be allowed to